



UNITED NATIONS
CORRESPONDENTS ASSOCIATION:
JOURNALISM



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Letter From the Editor-In-Chief



Greetings Delegates!

“I write to remember, and I remember in order to write.” -Mahmoud Darwish

My name is Jayanti, and I am delighted to be serving as the Editor-in-Chief for this edition of Inter SMUN. As you represent people, countries, and diverse portfolios in a Model United Nations conference, and as their names sit heavy on our tongues like fragile syllables we learn to pronounce carefully, let us remember that we carry flags that are not ours, histories that do not belong to our bodies, but they are struggles, griefs and hopes we inherit, even if for a fleeting weekend. I hope Sanskriti allows you to inherit both the benign and the significant, almost decorous emotions, in their most meaningful form. I hope, even for a brief moment, it gives you all the space to discuss discursive regimes, and to believe; for we believe empathy, spoken aloud, can challenge the normative framework of power, creating our own paradigm of change.

In a world where truth is often bartered away for convenience and is silenced beneath the ragged weight of deceiving lies, journalists persist as a defiant and alive force. The role of journalism is to take the ignored and saturate it with a new meaning. To transform raw facts into a humane and undeniable

form. It's to ensure remembrance. Whenever voices lathered in revolution fall short, your pens will diligently tell the tales of all that remains alive and dead (figuratively). In a way, this is a Russian Roulette of diplomacy. You must create strategic alliances, and you must tackle each crisis, seldom without bias. During this conference, histories are being written and rewritten, and they all need you.

Personally, I started my UNCA journey in seventh grade, and years later, here I still am, with the same fascination and conviction you would've found middle-school-me to have with writing and expressing her rather loud opinions.

Coming back to the topic, during the three days of the conference, even if your words tremble, remember: trembling is how wings begin. Speak not because the world is here to listen, but because somewhere, a border is learning how to tighten its fist as we stagnate in the comfort of silence. I invite you to see silence turn into courage, as someone raises their pallid hand, like a white flag, or a warning, or a prayer. Outside, the world keeps insisting on its capacity for ruin. Inside, we keep insisting on its capacity for repair. Some days, both are true. Most days, neither is enough. Therefore, we invite you to light the dark of someone else's war.

I hope you have a splendid time!

Warm regards

Jayanti Yadav

Editor in Chief

Sanskriti Model United Nations 14th Edition

Letter From the Head of Journalism



“In order for me to write poetry that isn’t political, I must listen to the birds, and in order to hear the birds, the warplanes must be silent.”

~ Marwan Makhoul

Greetings delegates!

To recognise the familiar all-consuming passion and the unquenchable thirst to quote French law as easily as the night sky turns dark, to memorise all of Churchill’s work by dawn, the addiction to write in labyrinthine sentences as if it were merely breathing, is to understand what drove me to step into my very first Model United Nations conference. The mere act of acknowledging the inner raconteur within all of us is to realise that even the most reticent voice in this discussion is louder than the most deafening cry of the tyrannical mob.

Whether your poison may be the quiet hours of the night illuminated solely by the glaring light of your laptop screen, or whether it may be crumpled papers and half-drunk coffee cups in the hotel café, the underlying truth remains unchanged: as you pick up the quill, your soliloquies metamorphose. Many

of you may fail to realise it, but each word uttered, each word scribbled, every pause and inflexion, all culminate in the very existence of the discourse and debate we revere as democracy.

I fail to utilise, befittingly, the English lexicon in a manner which allows me to elucidate the veracious impact of the mere notion of a Model United Nations, and therefore, feel the acute need to express my sentiments by way of the phrase, “*Malo periculosam, libertatem quam quietam servitutem*”. Quoted additionally by a contentious yet significant figure of American history, Thomas Jefferson, its literal translation goes along the lines of “I prefer dangerous freedom over peaceful slavery”; Latin may be what some might term a “dead language”, yet its phrases ring true in the hallowed thresholds of the present.

As those three days creep by and the mist settles, condensing into minuscule dew droplets on the windowsill, a phenomenon described best as a “whirlwind” may begin to subside within your body. It is my duty and privilege to advise you to embrace the unknown; fear not the void, nor the darkness, nor even the formidable ravine staring up at you with yearning in its midnight eyes. Instead, let yourself be carried away by the Stygian waves, consuming every inch of your being, yet leaving behind only the bravest parts of you.

Thus, delegates, it is not polished arguments or silencing rhetoric we wish to see, but the most courageous version of you, for to err is human and to rise divine.

I wish you all the very best!

With warm regards

Deeksha Singh

Head of Journalism

Letter From the Head of Journalism



Greetings, delegates!

"There is no greater agony than bearing an untold story inside of you. "

- Maya Angelou

Writing, for me, has always been the catharsis of all pent-up emotions, ideas, or the mere exasperation of boredom - the infallible remedy to all worldly miseries and afflictions. An escape from the torment of mundane existence or just a way to entirely unburden yourself after a bad day. Picking up a pen will vest you with the power of a creator, and compel you to make countless drafts, notes, and memos until your work effortlessly combines the clarity of your thoughts and

the musicality of your words, satiating a seemingly overwhelming perfectionist urge to conjure a flawless creation.

That being said, a journalist's responsibility is not simply limited to searching for the truth. It also involves being engaged in a perpetual struggle of employing a powerful narrative that captures your argument. In a convoluted world that is anything but black and white, journalists must meticulously and convincingly portray their vision of the truth and absolute. A few of the many ingredients that make up a dedicated journalist include an unwavering commitment to their cause, a vociferous expression, and a balanced and eclectic perspective. Mastering the art of incorporating your own stylistic articulation and imbuing mundane facts with a sense of life and agency is a tool that can immensely transform your writing.

At the beginning of my MUN journey, I remember the familiar and inordinate feeling of apprehension and fear as a seventh grader. The air was laden with an eerie sense of uncertainty, as I vividly remember watching my seniors fervently argue while I struggled to convince myself to speak. Nevertheless, it was perhaps my passion for writing that helped me find a sense of solace in my first conference, while I learned and made hundreds of mistakes as well. Ultimately, MUN undeniably helped me inculcate a variety of skills and improve in innumerable ways, as it will for you too.

The three days of the committee may feel incredibly gruelling and stressful at first, as you will be battling deadlines by burning the midnight oil or vehemently challenging other delegates while firmly gripping your own biases. However, SMUN is also an opportunity to be embraced to learn and grow as a person and push your limits as a writer and debater. Let this conference be an enriching experience to truly step out of your comfort zone and imbibe lessons that will undoubtedly serve you in years to come.

Looking forward to meeting you all!

Best regards,

Aaditri Prasad

Head of Journalism

Letter From the Additional Director of Journalism



Greetings, delegates!

"There can be no higher truth in Journalism than to tell the truth and shame the Devil"

-Walter Lippmann

Uncovering the deepest layers of the most brazen speeches, finding a story hidden in corners donning the farce of innocence, sparking discord through careful declarations, and allowing intangible words to flow through your pen, until all you can do is step back a thousand paces to make sense of your own masterpiece – *that* is what I find to be the true essence of journalism.

As a middle-schooler, I stumbled into the world of Model United Nations, armed with nothing but my own obstinate curiosity and a deep passion for staying far away from my classroom. And in that world, I remained for years to come, perpetually five minutes away from submitting paperwork too late, yet astoundingly immersed in every dramatically haphazard speech and in the euphoric moments of discovering the perfect set of syllables to capture the emotion behind my newest words.

It is in our moments of greatest doubt that the ink of our pen bleeds its deepest, and the gashes we leave on the paper confess the greatest truths. When lost for words, simply set aside all judgments you harbour against your own breach of silence, and allow your intuition to speak. The true difference is made by the valour behind daring to unleash the thoughts from the confines of one's mind, whether they be quiet whispers meant for one's ears alone, or a scream of a thousand voices rioting against the beliefs of the world.

Represent the voices of a few, and you will be delivering justice to countless, those forgotten centuries past and those who have yet to experience the new day marked by the nth rising of the Sun.

At SMUN, you will be challenged to no bounds and pushed to new limits. However, every moment of hardship you face is simply an obstacle beckoning you closer on your path to the sweet ecstasy of victory and the wisdom gained only through mistakes made – it is ever most pertinent to allow your voice to be heard.

And thus, I welcome you to the United Nations Correspondents Association.

Yours sincerely

Disha Karmakar

Additional Director

United Nations Correspondents Association – Journalism

Letter From the Additional Director of Journalism



“The first duty of a newspaper is to be accurate, but the second is to provoke.”

— Arthur Sulzberger, Sr.

Dear delegates,

What does it mean to be a journalist? I could tell you that it is an act of revolution. Silent whispers in the shadows of authoritarianism that transform into something unimaginably larger. I could tell you it is an act of responsibility. To walk into rooms carrying the weight of a thousand victims, to struggle against power that seeks to crush it. I could tell you it is an act of honesty. That to be a journalist is to tell the truth.

But I wouldn't be right. Before all of those glorious descriptions of journalism lies a more fundamental, urgent definition. To be a journalist is to be a moralist, through and through. UNCA-J is perhaps singular in this demand for morality, and that is why it remains my favourite committee. No matter what rivalries have torn your nations apart, no matter what side of the war you are on, in this committee, you are bound by morality.

Your truths may differ depending on your allocation. After all, what is the truth but an amalgamation of a million perspectives? And through the course of this committee, you will not only explore the

agenda but also confront these varying truths through debates and speeches. To find your agency's truth is the trick. Because no matter how 'difficult' an allocation, every nation has its justification, grounded in some morality that you must find and defend. To participate in UNCA-J is to understand this tenet of journalism.

As we delve into the Arab Spring, you will find that the truth is subjective. You will face crises that will seem insurmountable, but while you defend your stance, you must fall back on morality and your duty to the people. For the truth may be subjective, but morality is constant, although often tested.

I hope this conference helps you understand perspectives with a deeper nuance. I hope it persuades you to interrogate and dissect power better than before. But most importantly, I hope you cherish SMUN as much as I did. SMUN is challenging, no doubt, but I assure you, it's infinitely more rewarding. Late-night research, endless lobbying; drafting press conference questions, speaking in open floors powered by zero sleep and crazy amounts of caffeine can be terrifying. But embrace the chaos, delegates, immerse yourself in it, and you enter an entirely different world.

Welcome to UNCA-J!

Warm regards

Sharadha KV

Additional Director

UNCA-J

Introduction to the UNCA

Established in 1948, the United Nations Correspondents Association represents the UN press corps regarding media access and news coverage issues. It comprises over 200 correspondents and producers from over a dozen nations, including scores of member states, publications, news agencies and broadcasters. As a representative organisation, it strives to uphold journalistic ideals and protect the rights and privileges of the press.

The relationship between the UNCA and the Secretary-General is based on an agreement signed on 16th November 1995 and included in the UNCA constitution, which unites correspondents, diplomatic delegation members, Secretariat officials, other distinguished personalities and the Department of Public Information. The UNCA draws its authority from its constitution, which stipulates a mandate and a clear code of conduct. This document represents the organisation's ideals and clarifies the several categories of membership and their tenures. The body is constituted of regular, associate, honorary and alumni members. An Executive

Committee governs it, wherein the officers of the Association include a President, First, Second and Third Vice Presidents, a Secretary, a Treasurer, and nine members-at-large.

Under the Dag Hammarskjöld Memorial Scholarship Fund, the UNCA provides recognition to young journalists spread across the globe. They are provided with a stipend to tour the United Nations and report from the General Assembly. The prestigious UNCA Excellence in Journalism Awards are presented every year. The UNCA is recognised each year by the General Assembly in a resolution approved under the auspices of the Committee to Review United Nations Public Information Policies and Activities, also known as The Committee on Information. The United Nations Correspondents Association issued a statement in 2014 after a surge of violence against journalists. The statement stressed the importance of press freedom.

The Political Spectrum

While researching one's agency bias, a journalist will ineluctably come across certain labels or terms that define the agency's position on the 'left-right' political spectrum. Owing to their ambiguous nature and the fluidity in their meaning, these terms can often be misconstrued and adversely affect how a journalist perceives their agency's bias. This section of the background guide shall thus delve into the intricacies of various positions on the political spectrum a person might find themselves aligning with. The political terms 'left-wing' and 'right-wing' took birth in the French Revolution of 1789. The left, in this political scenario, referred to the revolutionaries who called for an abolishment of the monarchy, while the right was constituted by monarchical loyalists. The terms left and right were not employed to name differing political ideologies, per se, but rather to seat proponents and opponents of the issue in a particular manner. However, today, the left and the right are distinguished by ideals that support change and uprising, and the urge to stick to the status quo, respectively.

The Left

In politics, the left refers to an umbrella of egalitarian ideologies and views purporting state control of major institutions of socio-economic life. Leftists tend to regard social welfare as the *raison d'être* of government. Left-wing politics traditionally preach a detachment from religion and support more liberal ideologies. The ideology of liberalism considers protecting and strengthening the freedom of an individual as the central matter in question. Socialism is an example of a standard left-wing ideology practised; communism, however, remains a more radical approach to leftist politics.

The Centre-Left

The centre-left refers to political ideologies and institutions that find a place on the left side of the political spectrum but inch closer to the centre than the left. Also known as the moderate left, it emphasises that the attainment of equality requires personal responsibility on the part of the individual through their abilities and talents. Centre-left ideologies generally support a mixed economy,

a system of social security, government regulation of private enterprises, etc.

The Centre

Centrism is typically a political worldview that involves accommodation and an optimum balance of social equality and social hierarchy. Centrists typically avoid ideologies that would categorise them as either leftist or rightist. A news agency with a centrist 'bias' would typically be neutral to all opinions on an issue.

The Centre-Right

Refers to political ideologies and institutions that find a place on the right side of the political spectrum but inch closer to the centre than the right. Economic liberalism has influenced the economic components of the current centre-right, which generally supports free markets and limited government spending. The moderate right is neither

universally socially conservative or culturally liberal, and it frequently blends both viewpoints with support for civil liberties and traditional values.

The Right

It refers to the part of the political spectrum where institutions are in favour of free enterprise and private ownership and further tend to support socially traditional hierarchies, ideas and nationalist beliefs. The ideology of nationalism believes in the unification of the state and the nation, in which case loyalty and devotion to the nation reign supreme. Right-wing politics is defined by a belief that particular social systems and hierarchies are inevitable, natural, normal, or desirable, with natural law, economics, or tradition frequently backing this perspective. In market economies, hierarchy and inequality may be considered as an inevitable outcome of traditional social distinctions or competitiveness. Right-wing politics is seen as the polar opposite of left-wing politics.

Introduction To Journalism

***"Good journalism is good business
practice; it's good ethics and good politics."***

– Mark Twain

We live in a world characterised by spontaneous political, social, and individual landscapes. With every article a journalist publishes, thoughts are moulded, minds are shaped, and a path for change is constructed, which questions each and every flaw made by those who are obligated to do good by the common masses. Journalism is often showcased as a mere portrayal of the latest information; however, the tumultuous intricacies of journalism can only be understood when placed in the shoes of a journalist.

Even in today's world, much of the world's population is deprived of access to free and credible information. The privation of something as fundamental as information regarding the ongoing events of the world

prevents the masses from making well-informed decisions both in the political and personal spheres of life. The right to freedom of speech and expression includes the right to a free press, as affirmed by Article 19 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights.

Journalists are obligated to ensure that they assemble, assess and present information for the masses to make informed and decisive decisions. The ultimate duty of a journalist remains to the truth and to the masses.

As a journalist of the UNCA, you will be expected to research your media house's bias and report from your allotted committee, keeping your bias in mind, write a plethora of articles and conduct press conferences while simultaneously combating crises endangering the freedom and credibility of the press. Further sections of the background guide will elucidate upon these tasks more extensively.

Tenets Of Journalism

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As journalists venture out into a labyrinthine and nuanced environment to uncover the truth, they are forced to combat a myriad of obstacles revolving around ethical and moral complications. In order to avoid such hindrances, the Society of Professional Journalists (SPJ) has laid out a few tenets that journalists must follow to promote ethical journalism:-

Journalists must seek out the truth.

1. Journalists must take complete accountability for their reportage.
2. Journalists must uphold the accuracy and quality of reports at all times and ensure that their sources are credible.
3. Journalists must provide extensive background information to avoid oversimplification of their stories.
4. Journalists mustn't misuse the information gathered from sources and must accredit sources where necessary.
5. Journalists must ensure the source's anonymity when asked, but unveil the motive behind the request.

6. Journalists must avoid suspicious and illegal ways to obtain information unless the discovery might be largely beneficial to the masses and bring forth what was wrongfully concealed.

7. Journalists must label advocacy, opinion and commentary.

8. Journalists must never portray half of the truth, mishandle data or warp facts.

Journalists must minimise harm.

1. Journalists must balance the necessity to release information with the distress its declaration may result in.
2. Journalists must be empathetic and compassionate interviewers. Their foremost duty is to the public, including their interviewee(s)
3. Journalists must recognise that legal access to information differs from justifying its publication on virtuous grounds.
4. Journalists must recognise that the common people have a greater right to privacy than public figures and carefully weigh the merits and demerits of releasing information.

Journalists must act independently.

1. Journalists must avoid conflicts of interest at all times and disclose when they suspect the same.
2. Journalists must not be persuaded by bribes. The profession may be demanding, but it doesn't warrant contaminated favouritism.
3. Journalists must not pay to obtain information from sources and must prohibit the favoured treatment of sponsors and advertisers.

Journalists must be ever-transparent.

1. Journalists must explain their ethical choices and procedures to audiences. They must encourage a civil discussion with the public about journalistic practices, coverage and news content.
2. Journalists shouldn't be unsure about their work's clarity and factuality and must expose unethical conduct wherever they view it.

Hindrances to Ethical Journalism

The fourth pillar symbolises the real-life practice of journalistic ethics.

Agency Bias

A press member is meant to be free from external influence to furnish relevant information. Ideally and ethically, the press should be free from any biases that come into play. However, biases can compromise the fulfilment of this 'duty to truth', whether it be a journalist choosing to retain information, to publish half-truths, or to manipulate statistics.

Consequently, since the inception of the press, bias has crucially altered how textual media interact with the world. This is despite the introduction of various laws across the globe to protect journalists, the practice of censorship is still enforced worldwide.

To be concise, the interplay of all events which compromise the whole truth results in heavy bribery of the media, extreme censorship, wrongful withholding of information, condemnation of reporters in the name of constitutional legislation and violence, etc. Moreover, it also creates a system of fear and manipulation.

Censorship

The press should ideally be an independent entity, free from governmental interference.

As journalists, you will encounter various situations during the conference where you will be compromised due to your agency's bias. While unfortunate, this is a critical aspect of journalism in the 21st century. Bias impacts everything. It is evil, but in terms of practicality, necessary.

Yellow Journalism

Usually refers to sensationalised and biased stories that media houses present as objective truths. It is driven by an incentive to improve profit margins and increase circulation. The very essence of yellow journalism goes against the spirit of trustworthy journalism. The aim of the press is to inform, not to make profits. When a news agency goes against its ethics for economic gains, it goes against the fundamental ideals on which the concept of journalism was founded. It uses various techniques like flashy and bright headlines, presenting biased information, only showing the popular side of a story, using uncredited information, etc. Yellow journalism largely affects social thought, thanks to the widespread reach of the media. It is the devil toying with the quill- unmotivated, uninspired, and vapid.

However, this freedom is upheld by strict authorities like the government, which often filters or redacts information published.

Almost every administration practises some form of censorship, the extent of which varies from administration to administration.

Censorship is universal, unrestricted by regime, country, ethnicity or race; it occurs in democratic and authoritarian nations.

In some cases, censorship might be justified; in others, it indicates a dictatorial leader. For example, censorship can take place to protect religious sentiments on account of national security. Censorship can be imposed on publishing a Nazi flag, the assertion of inferiority, etc. Unjustified censorship leads to conspiracy theories and mistrust of authorities.

Fake News

Generated as a political weapon, fake news/misinformation has become more and more prevalent with the advent of social media. The source of such news is malignant but can be verified using proper research to limit its repercussions. News can be fabricated to garner critical acclaim and accolades as well. One example of this is the Washington Post article titled 'Jimmy's World'. In September 1980, Washington Post reporter Janet Cooke wrote a profile on the life of an eight-year-old heroin addict. Despite some doubts about the story's veracity, it was submitted to the Pulitzer Prize Board for consideration. Cooke was awarded

the Pulitzer Prize for Feature Writing. The story was later found to be a complete fabrication, and the award was rescinded, making fake news one of the vilest obstacles in the quest for clean journalism.

Funding

Publishing houses may be government-funded or privately owned. In either case, the economic support is attracted from viewership and advertisements. Hence, paid advertising plays a big role in the content produced by news agencies. This system may give rise to yellow journalism, as well as the formation of bias due to commercial interests. As a consequence, journalists end up having to compromise their morals and ethics to protect the monetary benefits of their news agency. Thus, the first source to comprehend a news agency's bias is to check the source of funding. For example, the political bias of Fox News can be ascertained from the political relations of the Murdoch Group.

Lack of Safeguard

In numerous instances, the world over, it has been noticed that press members are not entitled to any special privilege, judicial or literary. Several court rulings have expressed the concern that giving special access to information to the press may serve as a proxy for general public access, and not exclusively to the news media. The practical result of this principle has been to mute the separate impact of the freedom of the press and effectively merge it with the guarantee of freedom of speech.

Time Constraints

With the advent of online media, being the first to report a story has become key to relevance in the media hierarchy. This twenty-four-hour news cycle has made thoroughness a rare commodity. Proper fact-checking is difficult on a very tight schedule. This leads to errors in reporting and results in increased redactions and confusion among the public.

The Duty Towards the Public versus the Individual

Well-researched articles are often at risk of hurting certain sections of society, despite the critical information they contain. This added burden of arriving at a reasonably ethical middle ground is tough to carry for a journalist. There is no one correct approach. Every story has a varied proportion of responsibility owed to the public. An ethical dilemma; crossroads await. The answer does not stem simply from within, but from external factors (such as an agency's sponsors) as well. Choices must be made carefully. Cautiously.

The answer to the approach of a news agency lies in its bias and internal code of conduct.

Lack of trust

Traditionally, journalists are considered the protectors of information, people who exercise an 'iron will' to remain 'value-neutral'. They are seen as individuals who can leave their own prejudices at home. However, recent cases of misinformation, plagiarism, and biased reporting have led to the news not being considered a trustworthy source of information anymore. This mistrust is largely due to the factors discussed before. The idea of modern journalists not respecting personal boundaries and using illegal measures to obtain information has strengthened this mistrust.

Agenda

Introduction

A sea of red, brimming with insurrectionary beliefs and the scarlet fury of a few thousand men, ebbed and surged until it reached the centre of the town; the true personification of revolutionary might. The embers flickering off of Mohammed Bouazizi's body had not yet extinguished when the city came alive.

A desperate act against corruption had metamorphosed into a raging protest as the Tunisian public took to the streets to make an outward display of their discontent with the current administration and their erstwhile tales of corruption, bribery, police brutality and violent suppression of dissent. Bouazizi's act exposed not only economic precarity but a deeper democratic deficit, where grievance had no lawful channel.

Tunisia became both a political and communicative blueprint for revolt. The

Tunisian Revolution demonstrated that control over territory no longer guaranteed control over meaning. Power struggled to keep pace with a media ecology that was fragmented, transnational, and resistant to central authority.

This agenda asks you to examine the media not as a neutral backdrop to revolution, but as a contested site of power. What you must do, now, delegates, is balance on the teetering tightrope, maintaining the fine line between balance and confidence in order to quell such an incident of sociopolitical disharmony. This is of foremost significance, or you may as well risk igniting another flame, burning not a single man this time, but all of West Asia instead.

Historical Background

Tunisia attained independence from France in 1956. At this turning point, Habib Bourguiba, the face of the nationalist movement, seized power. After being elected as interim President of the country, Bourguiba set out to implement key reforms marked by intense social progressivism. Women's rights, health and education were given unprecedented priority in the Arab region. The setting up of a Presidential system was one of these reforms. His foreign policy was marked by a pro-Western stance, as a result of which he garnered support from the U.S. and France.

Notwithstanding, Tunisia soon turned into a one-party state controlled by Bourguiba's Socialist Desturian Party by 1964. Bourguiba brutally suppressed any opposition, particularly Islamic conservationists and his rival, Salah Ben Yousseff's supporters. In 1975, he was declared 'President for Life' by the parliament, reflecting the cult of personality that had developed around him.

However, he achieved little success in the economic sphere. His government followed a socialist model. Following a period of economic decline, the Tunisian government faced several financial issues in the 1980s. The Bread Riots of 1983 were evidence of this issue. Between 1981 and 1987, unemployment rose significantly, coupled with rising inequality between prosperous northern regions and poor and drought-stricken southern regions.

This time also saw the rise of Islamist opposition, which complicated a political situation facing the threat of Bourguiba's repression. His failing health was the final straw. On 7 November 1987, Zine El Abidine Ben Ali, his prime minister, toppled his regime in a bloodless coup. As a regime change took place, the people, already led to desperation by poverty and unemployment, hoped for a better government. This hope was sustained by President Ben Ali's promises, which pledged civil liberties and constitutional reforms.

Upon taking office, one of his earliest reforms was to loosen restrictions on the press; state-controlled newspapers now had the liberty of publishing statements from the opposition—a minor liberty but one previously denied. Further, political prisoners were pardoned. In 1988, he changed the name of the ruling party to the Democratic Constitutional Rally. The international community, particularly the West, viewed these reforms as a prelude to a shift to a more democratic government.

However, conversely, President Ben Ali's regime entrenched Tunisia in an even more stifling political system. By manipulating constitutional and electoral processes, he secured a third term in 1999, winning a highly implausible 99.4 per cent of the vote. Gradually, Tunisia relapsed into a one-party state, ruled by a dictator once again.

This erosion of democracy was achieved by an increase in political repression. Repressive measures particularly targeted Islamist movements like *An-Nahdha* (Renaissance). Following a ban, the 1990s saw mass arrests and military trials (1992). As part of the crackdown, suspects' families- including women and children were targeted.

In prison, people braved intolerable conditions, spending months in solitary confinement, denied basic medical facilities. The situation deteriorated as prisoners faced systemic abuse under the pretext of interrogation. Physical discomfort, beating, food and sleep deprivation were frequent tools of torture employed by Tunisian state prisons.

Human rights violations reached their zenith when, even after release, prisoners were placed under constant state surveillance. This is evident from the case of Abdallah Zouari, an outspoken critic of the Tunisian government. He was jailed thrice, placed under constant police supervision and often prevented even from using the internet for communication purposes after being released in 2002. Zouari's case isn't isolated; such cases of harassment often continue, even when detention, arbitrarily imposed in the first place, does not. The administration frequently used separation from family, society and economic prospects as a means of control. Tunisia began to be referred to as an 'open-air prison', a country where expression was a crime and existence was marked by surveillance and torture.

In spite of severe control and repression, Tunisia saw significant economic growth (annual average of 5% till 2007) under President Ben Ali. In 2008, Tunisia's per capita GDP tripled from the amount in 1986. This increasing growth rate was the result of a revitalised tourism industry and sustained agricultural production, accompanied by positive relations with the European Union, indicating an export-oriented economic strategy. Reforms like the institution of the National Solidarity Fund, to combat poverty and terrorism, were hallmarks of his regime. However, these institutions were prone to corruption and thus weren't entirely successful. Furthermore, the benefits of the aforementioned economic development were unevenly distributed, reinforcing inequality across north-south regions.

In addition to this, Tunisia suffered from high rates of unemployment, especially among university graduates and the youth as a whole. The situation was so dire that it had been described as a 'demographic time bomb' by the World Bank. The rural and urban poor, especially small businesses facing the world market, had been left out of economic development measures.

Exacerbating the already heightened tensions were corruption scandals, at the heart of which was the Trabelsi clan: Ben Ali's family. The government's efforts of privatisation primarily benefited them. In 2010, WikiLeaks, an international non-profit, released U.S.

diplomatic cables which exposed the exorbitantly lavish lifestyles of members of the presidential family, who became the subject of the hatred of the common people. The documents also revealed mafia-like behaviour in commercial sectors. All business owners had to guarantee the presidential clan at least 10-20% of profits. These documents were analysed and disseminated by media partners like The Guardian, Le Monde, Der Spiegel, The NYT and Al Jazeera. Coupled with existing discontentment, this revelation led to increasing instability. The cables also revealed U.S. disdain for the regime, undermining previously secured American and French support. These reports faced heavy censorship, but they were nothing less than embers metamorphosing into the flames that set Mohamed Bouazizi and the rest of Tunisia ablaze.

Events Until Freeze Date

Precursory Events (1970 - 2000)

Across the Middle East and Northern Africa, there were multiple events that asserted the unregulated power of political leaders, which ultimately played a pivotal role in fueling the revolution. For instance, in Egypt, when Hosni Mubarak assumed his presidency in 1981, an Emergency Law was enacted to suppress his political opponents and enabled arbitrary detention. The regime of the Tunisian President Zine El Abidine Ben Ali was also characterised by deep-seated corruption and authoritarianism, despite initial success in his efforts to improve the economy. The overarching theme of such totalitarian ideologies, coupled with the absence of social, political and economic development, created an atmosphere of frustration among the people.

The Iraq Invasion (2003)

The US-led invasion aimed at a 'regime change' in Iraq and prevented Saddam Hussein from carrying out alleged nuclear, biological and chemical programmes, which resulted in several casualties and in a brutal aftermath. However, it perhaps also evidenced the idea of the possibility of dismantling supposedly unshakeable regimes.

The Kefaya (Enough) Movement in Egypt (2004)

The Egyptian Movement for Change was sparked by a coalition of political activists who publicly protested against Mubarak's regime

and his son's succession to power. It gave vent to the long-standing grievances on legal and political issues, civil liberties, unemployment and so on, though it faced a brutal crackdown. This groundbreaking event of challenging Mubarak's power also influenced later activism.

The Gafsa Mining Uprising in Tunisia (2008)

The protests erupted in response to the fraudulent results of a recruitment exam for the Gafsa Phosphate Company, which were not based on merit. This incentivised the local miners to revolt against the wealthy coastal government that paid little attention to their needs, through a prolonged six-month uprising. The Ben Ali regime quashed the revolt through military sieges, media blackouts and police brutality. However, the protesters were able to make use of early versions of several digital media platforms to bypass censorship to an appreciable extent. It is also considered a consequential uprising that paved the way for the Arab Spring to take place.

The Global Food Crisis (2007-2008)

This period was marked by an unprecedented spike in the prices of staple food items like wheat and rice, resulting in widespread poverty and protests. High oil prices and poor harvests made food highly expensive for the underprivileged sections, amplifying public unrest in the Middle East.

The Rise of Al Jazeera (2000s)

Al Jazeera was the first independent news agency in the Arab world to challenge state-controlled narratives by broadcasting debates as well as regional conflicts. Playing a pivotal role in the Arab Spring, it provided a medium for public dissent and catalysed the revolution against unchecked power.

The Self-Immolation of Mohamed Bouazizi (2010)

Mohamed Bouazizi's unlicensed food cart was confiscated, and he was reportedly harassed by local officials who prevented them from putting forth his complaint. The self-immolation of the fruit vendor in an act against the oppressive government was the immediate trigger of the Arab Spring.

Current Situation

It may very well have, *initially*, been an individual and isolated act of self-immolation, yet it has turned into the catalyst for a series of demonstrations since it occurred 3 days ago. His name, now echoing across every Tunisian alley and street, Mohamed Bouazizi, has since become the figurehead of the emerging fight against corruption and unemployment.

political power: the desire of authoritarian regimes to control narratives, and the growing impossibility of doing so in a digitised world.

It was on December 17th, 2010, in Sidi Bouzid, Tunisia, that Mohammed Bouazizi's cart of agricultural produce and weighing scales were confiscated, as he was found working without a permit. Refusing to pay a bribe to the officials confronting him, he was then publicly humiliated and even beaten up by the local law enforcement authorities and the municipal inspectors. Following the seizure of his vegetable cart, Mohammed Bouazizi attempted to appeal in the presence of the governor, but was denied a fair hearing and, henceforth, driven by torment, committed the horrific act.

Such an act of desperation triggered mass protests against the authoritarian regime. These were two issues of paramount concern often ignored by the Tunisian state, until now, that is. Political repression and media censorship were shown in their finest forms as the government attempted to adopt a defensive position and entirely erase any evidence of the radical act. What followed exposed a fundamental tension at the heart of modern

Timeline

→ 1950s onwards:

- Many Arab states gained independence from European powers.
- The rise of majorly centralised systems of governance was observed in North Africa and the Middle East.

→ 1970s:

A rise in global oil prices served as a catalyst for massive economic success in oil-exporting countries (Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Libya, etc.).

→ 1980s:

Oil glut caused a sudden detriment to oil prices, leading to economic downturn and a long-term unemployment crisis in the region.

→ Early 2000s:

- The movement for liberalisation of economies dramatically increased economic inequalities.
- Rising unemployment amongst educated youth.
- Growing “digital resistance”, originally in the form of radical blogs, such as the ‘Manalaa’ blog.

→ 2004:

The Kefaya movement in Egypt opposes the hereditary succession of the presidency. Blogs and SMS were used to coordinate protests.

→ 2008:

- The global food crisis severely impacted the Middle East and North African regions, many of which rely mainly on food imports. Widespread poverty led to increased dissent, such as the Egyptian general strike of 2008, which was organised with the use of digital media.
- Gafsa Mining Uprising in Tunisia over fraudulent hiring practices and high unemployment.

→ 2008 - 2010:

Crackdown on digital resistance by governments in countries such as Egypt, Tunisia and Syria. Bloggers would frequently be snatched off the streets by plainclothed officers, arrested and interrogated. By the end of 2010, several prominent Tunisian bloggers were in hiding or operating from exile.

→ **2009:**

The Green Movement in Iran constituted mass protests following a disputed presidential election. It was the first to transform Twitter into a revolutionary platform, with the use of the political hashtag “#whereismyvote”.

→ **June 2010:**

The killing of Khaled Said by Egyptian security forces. The incident sparked the creation of the ‘We are Khaled Said’ group on Facebook, contributing to the growing discontent of the people.

→ **November 2010:**

WikiLeaks released exposés, revealing the lifestyle and practices of Ben Ali’s family, which resonated with organised crime. The released cables served as fuel

for the rage of the working classes and activists.

→ **17 December 2010:**

The self-immolation of Mohammed Bouazizi in an act of protest against the government of Tunisia served as the final straw.

→ **17-20 December 2010:**

The government of Tunisia attempted to assert a “media blackout” by blocking digital sites such as YouTube to prevent the spread of videos displaying the Sidi Bouzid protests. Immediately after the self-immolation, the cyber police began hacking into the accounts of prominent bloggers and activists in order to delete their pages and survey their contact lists.

Media-Related Happenings

The Arab world was the bridge for paper between the East and the West. While China invented paper in the 1st Century CE, it was the Battle of Talas (751 CE) that brought the technology to the Abbasid Caliphate. By the 9th and 10th Centuries, paper mills were established in North Africa, replacing expensive parchment and brittle papyrus. This created a flourishing manuscript culture. However, because the calligraphic tradition was tied to the sanctity of the Quran, "printing" was resisted for centuries. Knowledge was decentralised but elite-driven. Unlike Europe's "Gutenberg Revolution," the printing press arrived in the Arab world primarily through two avenues: Christian missionaries and Colonial powers. The first official printing press in Tunisia, the *Imprimerie Officielle*, was established by the reformist Ahmad Bey. It was used primarily to publish the first official newspaper, *Ar-Raid at-Tunisi*.

The history of media in the Maghreb is inextricably linked to the struggle for sovereignty. Under the Ottoman *Tanzimat* reforms (1839–1876) and the *Nahda* (Arab Renaissance) intellectual movements, print journalism proliferated. The Egyptian governor Muhammad Ali had established *al-Waqa'i al-Misriyya* in 1828 (an Ottoman Turkish/Arabic gazette), and by the 1850s–1890s, newspapers and periodicals

flourished in major cities like Cairo and Beirut. Many early editors were scholars and nationalists who used the press to debate politics and society. In Tunisia, French colonial rule (1881–1956) also affected the press: French-language newspapers grew (e.g. *Le Tunisien*, founded 1907 to challenge colonial policies) even as Arabic papers often faced censorship.

When the first Arabic-language newspaper in Tunisia, *Ar-Raid at-Tunisi*, was established in 1860, it was never intended to be a platform for the public; it was a gazette for the Bey's decrees. This established a "top-down" information culture that survived the French Protectorate (1881–1956). During the colonial era, the French utilised the press to marginalise indigenous voices, leading to the rise of the nationalist press, such as *Le Tunisien*, founded by Ali Bach Hamba. These early news agencies were highly politicised from birth; they were either tools of the colonial administration or weapons of the independence movement. It was not until the French Protectorate began in 1881 that a "diverse" media landscape emerged, though it was deeply fractured along colonial lines. French settlers established papers like *Le Courrier de Tunisie* to defend colonial interests, which in turn provoked Tunisian intellectuals to launch the first French-language indigenous paper, *Le Tunisien*, in 1907. This era also saw a

"Golden Age" of satire. Between 1881 and 1920, dozens of satirical weeklies like *El-Moze'ej* (The Instigator) and *Kara-Kouz* (The Clown) used humour and caricature to expose the flaws of both the Beys and the French occupiers. There was no "neutral" middle ground.

When Tunisia gained independence in 1956, Habib Bourguiba did not create a free press; he created a "National" press. He viewed media as a vital organ for his project of "Tunisification." When Habib Bourguiba took power in 1956, he inherited this binary system and simply flipped the switch, turning the press into a monolithic mouthpiece for the Neo-Destour party. He viewed the media as a pedagogical tool to "civilise" and "modernise" the Tunisian citizenry, effectively making the journalist a civil servant. Every local radio station and newspaper was required to source its news from TAP dispatches. Simultaneously, the ERTT (Établissement de la Radiodiffusion-Télévision Tunisienne) was established in 1957, ensuring the state had a total monopoly over the airwaves.

The current media environment is the direct product of Zine El Abidine Ben Ali, who has held the presidency since November 7, 1987. Ben Ali, a former military officer and Minister of Interior, seized power in a "bloodless coup," declaring his predecessor, the ageing Bourguiba, medically unfit to rule. While he initially promised a "New Era" of democracy and pluralism, his regime quickly pivoted to a "security first" doctrine. This was fueled by a

fear of Islamist movements and a desire for absolute economic control. Ben Ali's rise to power was facilitated by his mastery of the internal security apparatus, and he applied this same "security" lens to information. He implemented "Economic Censorship" through the ATCE (Agence Tunisienne de Communication Extérieure). The ATCE functioned as a giant clearinghouse for all advertising. If a private daily like *Assabah* (founded in 1951) stepped out of line, the ATCE would simply cut their state-linked advertising, which accounted for up to 80% of their revenue. By 2010, the "independent" press had been largely starved into submission or bought by the President's family. For example, Ben Ali's son-in-law, Sakher El Materi, purchased a 70% stake in the venerable *Dar Assabah* media house in 2009, effectively ending its history of editorial independence just a year before the revolution.

Under Ben Ali, censorship became an invisible, structural force. In 1990, he created the Agence Tunisienne de Communication Extérieure (ATCE). On paper, it was a public relations body; in reality, it was the regime's economic guillotine. The ATCE controlled the distribution of all government advertising. In a country where the state was the largest economic actor, losing government ads meant financial death. Private newspapers like *Le Maghreb* were forced into self-censorship just to survive. Simultaneously, the Tunis Afrique Presse (TAP), the national news agency, became the "source of truth." All domestic and

international news had to pass through TAP's filters. If a protest occurred in the rural interior, but TAP did not issue a dispatch, it was as if the protest never happened. This created two Tunisiyas: the "Official Tunisia" presented in the newspapers, which was stable and prosperous, and the "Real Tunisia," which was increasingly frustrated by unemployment and corruption.

The regime faced a new challenge in the late 1990s: the Internet. Ben Ali initially embraced digital technology to attract foreign investment, making Tunisia one of the first African nations to provide widespread access. However, the regime soon realised that the internet allowed "the periphery" to talk back to "the centre." To combat this, the Agence Tunisienne d'Internet (ATI) was weaponised. They implemented one of the most sophisticated filtering systems in the world, nicknamed "Ammar 404" by the public. Whenever a citizen tried to access a site critical of the President's family, specifically the "Trabelsi Clan," who were widely accused of kleptocracy, they were met with a "404 Not Found" error page. The regime didn't just block sites; they hunted digital citizens. They engaged in "phishing" to steal Facebook passwords and monitored cybercafés. By 2010, the "Blackout" had extended from the physical page to the digital pixel.

The current crisis began on December 17, 2010, in the neglected interior town of Sidi Bouzid. Mohamed Bouazizi, a 26-year-old

vegetable vendor, had his scales confiscated by a municipal official. When he went to the governor's office to complain and was refused an audience, he doused himself in paint thinner and set himself on fire. This was an act of "anti-media," a desperate attempt to be seen by a regime that had made him invisible. In the immediate aftermath, the "Media Blackout" was total. The state-run TV channels, *Télévision Tunisienne 1 and 2*, ignored the event. They calculated that if they didn't show the flames, the fire wouldn't spread. They relied on the old playbook: isolate the town, cut the landlines, and wait for the "hoodlums" to grow tired.

As your committee meets today, on December 20, we are witnessing the historical failure of the Ben Ali media model. The "Blackout" has been pierced by two primary forces. First, the proliferation of camera phones allowed activists to bypass the TAP news agency. Ali Bouazizi, a relative of Mohamed, uploaded a video of the initial protests to Facebook. Because Facebook was "too big to block" without causing an elite backlash, it became the underground railroad for information. Second, the satellite network Al Jazeera acted as a megaphone. Denied a bureau in Tunis, Al Jazeera's editors began "crowdsourcing" their news, taking the grainy Facebook videos and broadcasting them back into Tunisia via satellite. Even if the regime blocked the internet, they could not block the signal from the sky. Today, December 20, the regime is still attempting to maintain the "Official Tunisia" narrative, but the "Real

Tunisia" is watching Sidi Bouzid burn on their television screens, and the silence of the state is

being interpreted not as stability, but as a confession of guilt.

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